

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

Grades 1–2

GRADES 1–2

35 MINUTES

READ-ALoud + CENTRES

SESSION GOALS

Students will: understand that the Harlem Renaissance was a time when Black artists, musicians, and writers created amazing work together; identify key vocabulary (jazz, poetry, silhouette, Great Migration); practise close observation of visual art; and make personal connections through writing and drawing.

PREPARATION

- Display: *Song of the Towers* or *Aspects of Negro Life* print or projection
- Tables set: differentiated activity cards (Green / Yellow / Red), pencils, crayons
- Read-aloud prepared: *Harlem* by Walter Dean Myers (1997) — ideal anchor text; *Jazz* by Walter Dean Myers also excellent

SESSION FLOW

- 0–5 min** **Hook:** Play 20 seconds of Duke Ellington. Ask: "What do you picture in your mind when you hear this music? What colours? What movements?" Take 4 responses. *"This music comes from Harlem, New York, about 100 years ago. Today we're going on a visit."*
- 5–15 min** **Read-Aloud:** Read *Harlem* by Walter Dean Myers. Pause at 3–4 spreads to ask: "What do you notice? What words sound like music? What feelings are here?" After reading: *"The words in that book were written by a poet — someone whose job is to put the world into the most powerful words possible. Langston Hughes did the same thing in the 1920s."*
- 15–20 min** **Art Look:** Display Aaron Douglas. Quick 5-question look: What do you see? What do the circles make you think of? Why no faces? What colours? If you could hear this painting, what would it sound like?
- 20–32 min** **Activity Cards:** Students work independently or in pairs on differentiated cards. Circulate and conference with at least 3–4 students. Encourage going beyond minimum responses.
- 32–35 min** **Share:** One student from each level shares. Close: *"You've just spent time with artists who lived 100 years ago. Their work was so good it still makes us feel something today. That's what great art does."*

Mini Museum Connection

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit. **Option 2 — Virtual Visit:** minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

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BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS — GRADES 1–2

Anchor Texts

- *Harlem* — Walter Dean Myers / Christopher Myers (1997) — Caldecott Honor; the essential Grades 1–2 Harlem text
- *Jazz* — Walter Dean Myers (2006) — stunning visual poetry about jazz
- *A Sweet Smell of Roses* — Angela Johnson — civil rights context, accessible
- *Zora and Me* — Victoria Bond / T.R. Simon — fiction based on Hurston's childhood

Supporting Reads

- *Poetry for Young People: Langston Hughes* — selected and illustrated edition; ideal for read-aloud
- *When Angels Sing: The Story of Rock Legend Carlos Santana* — Michael Mahin — music biography accessible format
- *Let the Children March* — Monica Clark-Robinson — civil rights, age-appropriate
- Aaron Douglas artist profile cards — printable from museum education sites

DIFFERENTIATION NOTES

At this level, the Green/Yellow/Red split primarily reflects reading scaffolding and writing expectation depth rather than topic difficulty. All students engage with the same art and same core ideas — the differentiation is in how much independent language production is expected. Red-level students at Grade 1–2 are ready for genuine critical thinking: asking *why* not just *what*.

DISPLAY SUGGESTIONS

- Feature display: Harlem Renaissance portraits — use library display boards to show Douglas, Hughes, Ellington, Hurston, McKay with brief bios at 1–2 grade reading level
- Student work wall: post silhouette drawings from the session alongside the Douglas print
- Book spine display: all Harlem Renaissance-related books face-out for the duration of the unit